

# Digital Research Team @ British Library

Our team's mission is to enable the use of the British Library's **digital collections and data** for research, inspiration, creativity, and enjoyment

[digitalresearch@bl.uk](mailto:digitalresearch@bl.uk) (Team email)

[Digital Scholarship Training Programme](#) (Blog Post)

[Digital Scholarship Blog](#) (Selected Posts)



## Defining Digital Scholarship/Digital Research

Though there are many definitions of digital scholarship out there, here we tend to favour the broadest of interpretations, that is, roughly, any type of innovative research that combines the methodologies from traditional humanities & social science disciplines with computational tools and digital methods provided by computing disciplines, such as data science.

Though closely aligned to, and generously informed by, the academic discipline Digital Humanities, "digital scholarship" allows us to consider more broadly the full range of innovative scholarly activities our users seek to undertake with our digital collections and data, across a diverse range of disciplines.

***"Digital scholarship" also defines a space for us heritage professionals, where research is undertaken in our own right, during the course of our daily work, which utilises computational methods in the curation, creation, collecting and sharing of our digital collections and data, but is not confined to formal academic pursuits or particular discipline.***

## What does "digital scholarship in libraries" look like?

- A subject librarian using a tool (like [OpenRefine](#)) for cleaning up a set of catalogue records to understand gaps in the metadata and collection scope
- A collaborative project to automatically transcribe handwritten texts from old manuscripts
- A library director reading up on the latest in AI and seeking expert perspectives to write a strategy document
- A metadata specialist packaging up digital collections into datasets that can be used by researchers
- A cataloguer using machine learning techniques to help improve collection metadata
- A digitisation project looking to use state of the art Automatic Text Recognition to improve the searchability of scanned printed books in under-resourced languages
- An analyst in the marketing department using data analytics and data science techniques to understand visitor trends
- A reference librarian pointing a researcher to datasets that might help them with their research enquiry
- An imaging technician creating a 3D model of a collection item

- A licensing manager keeping up to date on the latest uses of Text and Data Mining (TDM) in research so that digital collections meet the needs of library users and staff who want to work with them at scale
- A major interdisciplinary research project using the latest technologies to ask research questions of digital heritage collections (e.g. [Living with Machines](#))
- A curator creating an [online exhibit](#) with annotations
- A manager engaging in international knowledge exchange networks (e.g. [IIIF](#), [AI4LAM](#))
- An assistant librarian attending a summer school (e.g. the [Cambridge Data Schools](#))

## Our Priority Areas

Strategic activities for the Digital Research Team are guided by the following priorities:

- Advance public understanding of the innovative and computationally driven use of our digital collections and data for research, inspiration and enjoyment
- Strengthen the Library's capacity to utilise its digital collections and data effectively to deliver its strategic goals, portfolios, and programmes by harnessing our expertise in digital scholarship.
- Ensure the value of the Library's investment in digital scholarship methods and skills training for our staff is extended to bring wider benefit to the sector

## Types of activities we undertake

- Innovative research, experiments and projects that apply or develop new digital tools and methods to further enable the discovery and reuse of our vast digital collections
- Work across different BL departments and teams to develop and implement business as usual working models relating to creating, curating and working with digital collections and data
- Deliver bespoke training to staff all year long through the Digital Scholarship Training Programme, while contributing to development of new training materials for the wider sector

## Our Team

**Head of Digital Research:** Neil Fitzgerald

### Digital Curators:

Adi Keinan-Schoonbaert (Asian & African)  
Mia Ridge (Western Heritage)  
Nora McGregor (Eccles Institute)  
Rossitza Atanassova (Contemporary British)  
Valentina Vavassori (ATR)

### Universal Viewer Team:

Erin Burnand (Product Owner)  
James Misson (Research Software Engineer)  
Lanie Okorodudu (Senior Test Engineer)  
Saira Akhter (Research Software Engineer)

### Training Support Officer:

Deirdre Sullivan

### Research Software Engineer:

Harry Lloyd

## Recent/Notable Digital Research Team Projects

- Delivered the AI4LAM [Fantastic Futures 2025 Conference](#) at British Library in December 2025
- [Universal Viewer Team](#) working on new developments all the time!
- Contributed a chapter on [The Routledge Companion to Libraries, Archives, and the Digital Humanities](#) titled [Embedding Digital Humanities in the British Library](#)
- [Digital Scholarship & Data Science Topic Guides](#)
- [Living with Machines](#)
- Collaborations with [Wikisource communities](#), such as [Bengali](#), [Javanese](#) and [Urdu](#)
- [Computational Analysis of Catalogue Data](#) and [British Library Incunabula Catalogue Data - Transkribus](#)
- [Intro to AI for GLAM - Library Carpentries](#)
- [Handwritten Text Recognition](#) (HTR) for Bengali, Arabic, Chinese
- [Check this out: the British Library gets into gaming | The Guardian](#) Digital Storytelling Exhibition
- [Computing for Cultural Heritage](#)
- Environmental digital sustainability [training](#) and [guidelines for researchers](#)
- Contributing to the development of the Library's approach to AI and Writing ethical Principles for AI at the British Library
- British Library Everyday Coders Task and Finish Group
- Using LLMs as cataloguing aid

## Some of Our Favourite Networks

- [AI4LAM](#)
- [IIF/UV Open Collective](#)
- [Transkribus](#)
- [Wikimedia \(Wikidata\)](#)
- [Cambridge Data Schools - CDH](#)
- [Flickr Commons](#)
- [LIBER Data Science in Libraries](#)
- [LIBER Digital Scholarship & Digital Cultural Heritage](#)
- [RLUK Digital Scholarship Network](#)
- [Electronic Literature Organisation](#)
- [Museums Computer Group](#)
- [Library Carpentry](#)
- [The Programming Historian | Programming Historian](#)

## [Digital Scholarship & Data Science Topic Guides for Library Professionals](#)

Common applications of digital scholarship and data science methods and tools by library practitioners include:

- Data cleaning to work more efficiently with our catalogue data, making it more tidy for analysis
- Named-entity recognition to [classify data](#) about people, places, concepts
- Text mining to explore a bigger body of material computationally than by individually reading entire texts

- Digital mapping
- Computer vision to automatically extract, analyse and understand useful information from a single image or a sequence of images
- [Data visualisation](#) to make visual representations of datasets in graphs, charts, maps and other kinds of diagrams as a powerful way of analysing, exploring and presenting cultural heritage data
- Optical Character Recognition/Handwritten Text Recognition to create machine-readable text for search and analysis
- Data mining to improve library intelligence and support decision making by library management
- 3D modelling
- Digital storytelling
- Crowdsourcing as an engaging form of online volunteering supported by tools to manage tasks such as transcription, classification and geolocation to make our collections more discoverable
- Knowledge graphs/linked data for linking disparate collections online
- [IIIF](#) for delivering high-quality, attributed digital objects online at scale for researchers to annotate, examine, compare and share

## Digital Scholarship Training Programme

Running continuously since 2012, the DSTP provides **unique** opportunities for staff to learn how to do **cool** and **useful** stuff with our **digital collections** and **data**, and gain valuable **digital, data and ai literacy skills** and **knowledge** to support emerging areas of modern scholarship in the process!

Visit the [Digital Scholarship Training Programme](#) web page to learn more about the programme's objectives, formats, topics, and some stats.



<https://youtu.be/gmSicylAPQk>

All videos in series: [Introducing the Digital Scholarship Training Programme \(youtube.com\)](#)